

AI Benefits Advisor

Master Product Requirements Document

Independent Age

Version 2.8 | December 2025

Bottom Line Up Front

Independent Age will build an AI-powered Benefits Advisor that amplifies advisor capacity to help older people access £10.5 billion in unclaimed benefits annually. The recommended MVP is an advisor-facing copilot that listens to calls in real-time, provides contextual guidance, documents conversations, and generates client summaries and pre-filled application forms.

This is not a chatbot for elderly clients. It is a professional tool that makes advisors faster, more accurate, and more empathetic—reducing time-to-benefit from 6-12 weeks to 3-4 weeks.

Strategic Context

£10.5 billion in benefits goes unclaimed by UK pensioners annually. Independent Age's helpline handled 27,107 interactions in 2024 (+23% YoY), identifying £5.7 million in unclaimed benefits for 1,067 people. Demand regularly exceeds capacity—October 2024 saw 3,000 calls following Winter Fuel Payment changes. The opportunity is not to replace advisors but to multiply their impact.

1. Problem Statement

1.1 The Four Exclusions

Older people face multiple barriers to claiming entitled benefits:

1. **Temporal Exclusion:** Support services close at 5:30pm. Working carers (the "Midnight Carer") cannot access help when they need it. Vulnerable seniors may only have energy or support in evenings.
2. **Linguistic Exclusion:** Non-English speakers (Urdu, Punjabi, Bengali) face massive barriers. Bangladeshi and Pakistani communities have 44-56% poverty rates but lowest benefit take-up.
3. **Operational Bottleneck:** Human advisors spend 30-40% of call time on basic data collection and documentation rather than expert advice.
4. **Stigma:** Many eligible pensioners refuse help due to pride ("I don't want a handout"). Reframing as entitlement from lifetime National Insurance contributions is essential.

1.2 The Eligibility-to-Application Gap

Current benefit calculators (Turn2Us, EntitledTo, Policy in Practice) assume users know complex inputs like "eligible rent." They do not explore disability or care needs in depth, do

not support application completion, and do not provide pre-filled summaries. The result: high abandonment between eligibility checks and actual claims.

1.3 The Five Priority Benefits

Benefit	£ Unclaimed	Non-Claimants	Take-up	Primary Barrier
Attendance Allowance	£5.2 billion	1.1+ million	~40-50%	Lack of awareness (60% don't know they qualify)
Pension Credit	£2.5 billion	910,000 families	62%	Pride/stigma; assumption of ineligibility
Council Tax Reduction	£2.8 billion	2.7 million	62%	Local variation; separate application required
Housing Benefit	£1.1 billion	230,000 families	85%	Complexity; assumption already receiving via PC
Carer's Allowance	£1.3-2.3 billion	400-500,000	70-75%	Complex earnings threshold cliff-edge

Gateway Benefit Strategy:

Pension Credit unlocks Council Tax Reduction, free TV licence (75+), Winter Fuel Payment, NHS free prescriptions and dental care, and Warm Home Discount. A single Pension Credit application can unlock £3,000-5,000+ annually.

1.4 Ethnic Disparities in Financial Poverty

Data from JRF UK Poverty 2025 and Centre for Ageing Better reveals stark ethnic disparities in poverty rates—with the communities most in need facing the greatest language barriers to benefits advice:

Ethnic Group	Poverty Rate (All Ages)	Poverty Rate (50+)	Pension Income Gap
Bangladeshi	56%	34%	£231/week less than White Other pensioners
Pakistani	49%	44%	£157/week less than White British pensioners
Black African	40%	—	Data limited
Other Asian	39%	—	Data limited
White	19%	18%	Baseline

Key Findings:

- Bangladeshi and Pakistani communities have poverty rates 2.5-3x higher than White population
- Among 50+, 44% Pakistani and 34% Bangladeshi in poverty vs 18% White
- Asian pensioner families: £500/week gross income vs £731/week White Other
- These communities more likely to rely on means-tested benefits but less likely to claim them
- Workers from Bangladeshi/Pakistani communities more likely to opt out of workplace pensions

Strategic Implication:

Communities with highest poverty rates face greatest language barriers to benefits advice. AI supporting Bengali/Urdu/Punjabi directly addresses intersection of linguistic exclusion and financial hardship.

Sources: JRF UK Poverty 2025, Centre for Ageing Better State of Ageing 2023-24, Family Resources Survey.

2. Target Users & Personas

2.1 Primary User: Independent Age Advisors

The MVP serves advisors, not clients directly. Advisors are experts who need speed, accuracy, and information density—not oversimplification.

Advisor Needs

- Real-time call context and prompts
- Quick access to complex benefit interactions (e.g., Carer's Allowance + State Pension overlapping entitlement)
- Automatic documentation and summary generation
- Pre-filled application forms to review
- KPI tracking and workflow management

2.2 Secondary Users: Clients (via Advisor)

Persona: "The Excluded Senior" (Margaret, 78)

- Lives alone in Bradford
- Struggles with mobility and dressing
- Has never applied for Attendance Allowance—didn't know it existed
- Finds forms intimidating
- *"I've never asked for help—I don't want a handout"*

Goal: Understand eligibility and get help completing forms without feeling patronized.

Persona: "The Midnight Carer" (Daniel, 54)

- Full-time job; caring for mother with dementia
- Can only call during lunch or after 6pm
- Needs speed and clarity—no time for bureaucratic runaround
- Prefers WhatsApp/text over phone calls

Goal: Quickly gather application-ready information for mother's benefits.

Persona: "The Non-English Speaker" (Mrs. Khan, 75+)

- Primary language: Urdu/Punjabi (Mirpuri dialect)
- Landline user; not digitally connected
- Husband deceased two years ago—may be eligible for bereavement benefits
- *Speaks in mixed Urdu/English: "Beta, I am worried. Mera gas bill bahut high hai."*

Goal: Communicate in her language and understand what help is available.

3. MVP Approach: Advisor Copilot

3.1 Strategic Rationale

Rather than building a consumer-facing chatbot (high risk, long development, digital exclusion concerns), the MVP is an advisor-facing multimodal copilot that:

- Listens to calls in real-time and provides contextual suggestions
- Documents conversations automatically
- Generates client summaries and follow-up letters
- Pre-fills application forms for advisor review
- Tracks KPIs and creates operational dashboards

This mirrors the Citizens Advice Caddy model: AI enhances human advisors rather than replacing them. All responses are validated by humans before reaching clients.

3.2 Core MVP Features

Feature	Description
Call Listening	Real-time transcription with speaker diarization. Supports English, Urdu, Punjabi (Mirpuri), Bengali. Detects code-switching between languages.
Contextual Prompts	AI suggests follow-up questions, flags missed benefit opportunities, reminds advisor of eligibility criteria. "Client mentioned mobility issues—consider prompting for Attendance Allowance."
Safeguarding Alerts	Automatic detection of crisis indicators: severe deprivation ("no heat", "no food"), self-harm language, potential financial abuse, cognitive impairment signs. Triggers "Red Cord" protocol.
Auto-Documentation	Generates structured case notes from conversation. Extracts key data: DOB, region, income sources, savings bracket, health conditions, household status. Advisor reviews and edits before saving.
Client Summary	Plain-English letter to client summarizing: benefits discussed, likely eligibility, next steps, required documents, timeline expectations. Ready for advisor review and send.
Form Pre-Fill	Maps conversation data to official form fields. Initial scope: Pension Credit (online), Attendance Allowance (AA1), Housing Benefit/CTR (common fields). Advisor reviews before submission.
Benefit Calculator	Integration with EntitledTo or Turn2Us API for indicative entitlement calculations. AI handles conversation; deterministic code handles arithmetic.
Stigma Reframing	Suggested language when client expresses reluctance: "It's not a handout—you've paid National Insurance your whole life. This is money set aside for contributors like you."

3.3 Advisor Dashboard & KPIs

The system provides operational visibility for advisors and managers:

Real-Time Metrics

- Call duration (current and average)

- Benefits identified during call
- Estimated entitlement value
- Safeguarding flags triggered

Operational KPIs

Metric	Target	Notes
Average call duration	25-35 mins (from 45-60)	15% reduction target in Y1
Time from first contact to submission	3-4 weeks (from 6-12)	40-50% reduction
Amount claimable (identified)	£25m Y1 (from £5.7m)	5x increase
Application completion rate	70% (from 45%)	Initial contacts → submitted
Advisor satisfaction	4.7/5 average	Efficiency + reliability CSAT
Safeguarding incidents flagged	100% detection	Zero false negatives

4. Conversation Flows & Behavioral Specifications

4.1 The Gatekeeper Flow (Consent)

Constraint: No data collection without explicit consent. This applies whether the advisor or AI is leading.

Example Script (AI-Assisted)

"To help check what benefits you might be entitled to, I'll need to ask some personal questions about your health, living situation, and finances. Everything you tell us is confidential. Is it okay to continue?"

If No/Silence → *"That's absolutely fine. We're here when you're ready. Can I send you some information to read at your own pace?"*

4.2 The Code-Switching Flow (Multilingual)

Requirement: Handle mixed-language sentences common in British South Asian communities.

Example Conversation

User (Urdu/English): *"Beta, I am worried. Mera gas bill bahut high hai (My gas bill is very high)."*

AI Prompt to Advisor: "Client is worried about high energy bills. This may indicate eligibility for Warm Home Discount (requires Pension Credit) or Cold Weather Payments. Consider asking about heating and income."

Advisor: *"I understand you're worried about the gas bill. Let me check if you might qualify for some help with heating costs. First, are you living alone, or with family?"*

4.3 The Safeguarding Protocol ("Red Cord")

Requirement: Safety takes absolute priority over data collection.

Trigger	Action
Severe Deprivation <i>"No heat", "No food", "Can't afford medication"</i>	Stop benefit questions. AI prompts advisor: "Crisis indicators detected. Prioritize immediate needs." Offer emergency contact, food bank referral. Flag case URGENT_POVERTY.
Self-Harm/Suicide <i>"Don't want to go on", "What's the point"</i>	HARD STOP. AI displays Samaritans script for advisor. Flag case URGENT_HARM. Supervisor notification.
Financial Abuse <i>"My son handles my money", "Someone else opened this account"</i>	AI flags: "Potential financial abuse indicator." Advisor uses judgment. If concerned, offer private callback option. Flag case SAFEGUARDING_REVIEW.
Cognitive Impairment <i>Confusion, repetition, inconsistent timeline</i>	AI notes indicators for advisor. Suggest: "Would it be helpful to have a family member or friend join us?" Adjust pace and complexity.

4.4 The Stigma Reframing Flow

Requirement: Counter "handout" objections using entitlement framing.

User: *"I don't want a handout. I've never taken a penny from the state."*

AI Suggested Response: *"It's not a handout. You've paid National Insurance your whole working life—that's exactly what these benefits are for. People like you, who've contributed, are entitled to this support. Not claiming it doesn't save it for someone else; it just stays unclaimed."*

Alternative framing: *"You've already paid for this. It's like paying into an insurance policy and never claiming when you need it."*

5. Guardrails & Safety Framework

5.1 Absolute Red Lines

The AI must NEVER:

1. **Guarantee eligibility** — Only DWP/local authority can determine final eligibility
2. **Perform benefit calculations** — Must use calculator API; LLM cannot do arithmetic
3. **Submit applications without human review** — Advisor must approve all submissions
4. **Continue if safeguarding triggered** — Red Cord protocol takes immediate priority
5. **Provide Scottish/NI-specific advice** — Different benefit systems; must transfer to specialist

5.2 Warning Signs for Human Review

Supervisors should investigate if they observe:

- AI cites specific £ amounts without API call logged
- AI says "you will definitely qualify" or similar guarantees
- AI skips savings/capital questions for means-tested benefits
- AI conflates different benefits (e.g., confuses AA with PIP)
- Caller expresses confusion or contradicts AI's summary
- Third party appears to be controlling the conversation
- "UNSOURCED" flag appears in reasoning panel
- Call exceeds 20 minutes without clear progress

5.3 Reasoning Transparency Panel

Every AI response includes a visible reasoning panel showing:

- **WHY** the AI is asking each question
- **WHAT** sources inform the guidance (DMG chapter, GOV.UK page, rate table)
- **Confidence level** (HIGH / MEDIUM / LOW / UNSOURCED)
- **Current line of enquiry** (e.g., "Exploring Pension Credit → Severe Disability Addition")

6. Architecture & Platform Design

6.1 Embeddable Platform Approach

The AI Benefits Advisor is designed as an embeddable service that can be deployed across multiple channels and partners:

- **API Layer:** RESTful API for integration with partner systems
- **SDK:** JavaScript/React SDK for web embedding
- **Widget:** Drop-in widget for council websites and partner portals
- **Shared Intelligence Core:** Central knowledge base and reasoning engine

6.2 Technical Stack

Component	Technology	Role
Telephony	Twilio (Elastic SIP)	Physical line management, UK numbers
Voice Orchestration	Vapi.ai	Turn-taking, silence detection, latency management
Transcription	Deepgram Nova-2	Speech-to-text optimized for accents, UK English
Intelligence	Azure OpenAI (GPT-4o)	LLM brain, hosted UK South (GDPR compliant)
TTS	Azure Neural TTS	Voice: en-GB-RyanNeural (polite, mature)
Calculation Engine	EntitledTo API	Benefit calculations (LLM must not do math)
CRM	Salesforce	System of record, case management
Knowledge Base	RAG (Pinecone/Weaviate)	Vector search over DWP guidance, factsheets

6.3 Logic vs. LLM Separation

Critical Design Principle: The LLM handles empathy, language, and data extraction. Deterministic code handles arithmetic.

- **LLM does:** Conversation flow, language translation, extracting structured data from natural speech, generating summaries
- **Calculator API does:** Pension Credit entitlement, tariff income from savings, Housing Benefit calculations
- **Rule:** The LLM must NEVER perform arithmetic. It must use function calling to send variables (income, savings) to the calculation layer.

7. Scope Definition

7.1 MVP Scope (V1)

Element	In Scope
Benefits	Pension Credit, Attendance Allowance
Geography	England and Wales (with Welsh language support)
Primary Channel	Advisor copilot (call listening + prompts + documentation)
Languages	English (primary), Urdu, Punjabi (Mirpuri) for transcription
Pilot Region	West Yorkshire (Bradford/Leeds)
Outputs	Call notes, client summary letter, pre-filled PC/AA forms

7.2 Explicitly Out of Scope

Excluded	Reason
Autonomous applications	No DWP submissions without human review. Risk too high.
Scotland/Northern Ireland	Substantial devolution complexity (11 different benefits in Scotland). Phase 2.
ESA, PIP, Universal Credit	Complex disability assessment. Remain advisor-only for now.
Appeals and tribunals	Requires legal expertise beyond initial advice.
Consumer-facing chatbot	Phase 2. MVP proves accuracy with human-in-the-loop first.
Council Tax Reduction (full)	300+ local schemes. Via partner integration only.

7.3 V2+ Expansion Roadmap

1. Add Council Tax Reduction (via partner integration)
2. Add Housing Benefit
3. Add Carer's Allowance
4. Multilingual expansion: Bengali, Welsh
5. Scotland (Social Security Scotland partnership)
6. Consumer-facing WhatsApp chatbot (post-accuracy validation)
7. 24/7 out-of-hours triage agent

8. Knowledge Base & Source Authority

8.1 Source Hierarchy

The AI's knowledge base follows a strict hierarchy of authority:

Priority	Source	Access	Use Case
1 (Highest)	DWP Decision Makers' Guide (DMG)	Public (OGL)	Primary authority for legacy benefits (PC, AA, HB)
1	Advice for Decision Making (ADM)	Public (OGL)	Primary authority for UC/PIP
2	GOV.UK benefits content	Public (OGL)	Structured, continuously updated citizen guidance
2	Benefit rate tables (annual)	Public (OGL)	Essential arithmetic data
3	Independent Age Factsheets	Internal	Plain-English guidance; organizational voice
4	EntitledTo Calculator (API)	Licensed	Deterministic calculations—AI must not do math
5 (V2)	CPAG Welfare Benefits Handbook	Licensed (£162.50/yr)	Edge cases, appeals, complex interactions

8.2 Benefit-Specific Knowledge

Pension Credit

- **Guarantee Credit:** Tops up weekly income to £218.15 (single) / £332.95 (couple)
- **Capital rules:** £10,000 disregard; tariff income of £1/week per £500 above
- **Gateway benefits unlocked:** Council Tax Reduction, Cold Weather Payments, Warm Home Discount, free TV licence (75+), NHS costs

Attendance Allowance

- **NOT means-tested:** Income and savings irrelevant
- **Lower rate:** £72.65/week (day OR night care needs)
- **Higher rate:** £108.55/week (day AND night care needs)
- **Key concept:** "Needs help" not "receives help"—potential need counts

Benefit Interactions to Flag

- **Carer's Allowance + State Pension:** If State Pension > £83.30/week, no direct CA payment but "underlying entitlement" can increase Pension Credit
- **Attendance Allowance + Pension Credit:** AA can trigger Severe Disability Addition in PC (extra £81.50/week)
- **Housing Benefit + Council Tax Reduction:** Must apply separately; not automatically linked

8.4 Master Knowledge Base Sources

The following sources form the authoritative knowledge base. All sources available under Open Government Licence (OGL) unless noted. URLs and refresh requirements documented for operational data pipeline.

Primary Decision-Making Guidance (DMG)

These are the authoritative sources DWP decision makers use:

Source	Details
DMG Vol 10 Ch 61: Attendance Allowance and DLA	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/decision-makers-guide-vol-10 Coverage: Primary authority for AA eligibility, care needs, day/night conditions, rates, special rules
DMG Vol 10 Ch 60: Carer's Allowance	URL: (same publication as above) Coverage: CA rules, earnings threshold, overlapping benefits
DMG Vols 13 & 14: State Pension Credit	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/decision-makers-guide-vols-13-and-14-state-pension-credit-staff-guide Coverage: PC entitlement, guarantee credit, savings credit, capital rules, housing costs, additional amounts
DMG Vol 1: Decision Making and Appeals	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/decision-makers-guide-vol-1 Coverage: Appeals, revision, supersession rules (cross-benefit)
Medical Guidance for DLA/AA Decision Makers	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/medical-guidance-for-dla-and-aa-decision-makers-adult-cases-staff-guide Coverage: A-Z of medical conditions and typical care needs

Citizen-Facing Guidance (GOV.UK)

Plain-English guidance for claimants:

Source	Details
Attendance Allowance Overview	URL: gov.uk/attendance-allowance Coverage: Overview, rates, eligibility, how to claim
Pension Credit Overview	URL: gov.uk/pension-credit Coverage: Overview, eligibility, gateway benefits, how to claim
Pension Credit Technical Guidance PC10S	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/pension-credit-technical-guidance Coverage: Detailed adviser guidance with worked examples, April 2025 rates
Pension Credit Toolkit	URL: gov.uk/government/publications/pension-credit-toolkit Coverage: Stakeholder resources, myth-busting, outreach materials
Carer's Allowance Overview	URL: gov.uk/carers-allowance Coverage: Eligibility, rates, earnings rules

Refresh Requirements

Source Type	Refresh Frequency	Trigger
Benefit rate tables	Annually (April)	DWP announcement (typically November); apply in April

Source Type	Refresh Frequency	Trigger
DMG chapters	Quarterly check	DWP memo publications; check Summary of Changes documents
GOV.UK content	Monthly check	Content updated without announcement; RSS feed monitoring recommended
Claim forms	Monthly check	Version number in form footer; check publication date
Technical guidance	Annually (April)	Published with new rates; check April update

CRITICAL: AI must never provide eligibility guidance based on outdated rates or rules. If source refresh fails, system should flag uncertainty and recommend human advisor contact.

9. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
AI hallucination damages trust	High	Critical	"Shadow Mode": First 500 calls manually reviewed. Human-in-the-loop for all actionable advice. Weekly accuracy audits.
Translation errors	Medium	High	Bilingual human review for translated transcripts. Native speaker QA during pilot.
GDPR enforcement	Medium	Critical	Complete DPIA before launch. Azure UK South hosting. Explicit consent. Data minimization. No model training on client data.
Advisor adoption failure	Medium	High	Co-design with advisors from day one. Training program. Demonstrate time savings. Address concerns directly.
Missed safeguarding	Low	Critical	"Red Cord" protocol with multiple triggers. AI flags, human acts. Zero tolerance for false negatives in testing.
Cost overrun	Medium	Medium	Voice AI ~£0.15/min. Hard cap calls at 15 mins. AI wrap-up sequence at 13 mins. Monitor costs weekly.
Insurance gap	Medium	High	Confirm professional indemnity explicitly covers AI-assisted advice before launch.

10. Implementation Timeline

Phase 1: Foundation (Weeks 1-4)

- Week 1: Procure Twilio numbers, configure Azure/Vapi environment
- Week 2: Implement Salesforce API integration, define JSON schema
- Week 3: Build core prompts, configure knowledge base (DWP guidance)
- Week 4: Internal QA with native Urdu/Punjabi speakers

Phase 2: Shadow Mode (Weeks 5-8)

- Go-live with manual review of all transcripts
- Partner with 3 Boosting Advice Fund organizations
- Target: 500 calls with 100% human review
- Weekly accuracy audits and prompt refinement

Phase 3: Validated Operation (Weeks 9-16)

- Reduce manual review to 20% sampling
- Add form pre-fill for Pension Credit and Attendance Allowance
- Dashboard and KPI tracking live
- Target: 2,000 calls

Phase 4: Scale (Months 4-6)

- Expand to additional advisor teams
- Add Housing Benefit and Council Tax Reduction guidance
- Evaluate consumer-facing pilot (WhatsApp)
- Target: 5,000+ calls

11. Technology Partnership Opportunities

Independent Age's proposed technical stack—Azure for cloud infrastructure and Salesforce for CRM—aligns with two technology partners that offer substantial nonprofit programs. These present compelling co-creation opportunities that could significantly reduce costs while providing expert guidance on AI implementation.

11.1 Microsoft Azure & AI Programs

Microsoft offers comprehensive nonprofit support through several complementary programs:

Core Nonprofit Offers

- **Azure Grant:** \$2,000 (approximately £2,500) in Azure credits annually for eligible nonprofits
- **Microsoft 365:** Free for up to 10 users; discounted pricing for additional licenses
- **Dynamics 365:** Up to 60% discount for nonprofit organizations
- **Microsoft 365 Copilot:** Available at \$25.50/user/month (15% nonprofit discount)

Microsoft Elevate Initiative

Launched in 2024, Microsoft Elevate consolidates Microsoft's philanthropic efforts with a \$4 billion commitment over two years to support nonprofits with AI adoption. Key components include:

- **AI Skills Training:** Free courses from AI fundamentals to advanced Copilot implementation
- **Microsoft Nonprofit Community:** Peer support, mentoring, learning resources, and funding opportunities
- **Copilot Agent Playbook for Nonprofits:** Implementation guidance for AI-powered solutions
- **Tech for Social Impact Partners:** Network of certified partners specializing in nonprofit AI implementations

Relevance to AI Benefits Advisor:

Azure OpenAI (GPT-4o hosted in UK South) is the recommended LLM for the Benefits Advisor. Microsoft's nonprofit programs could provide: reduced hosting costs through Azure credits, access to Copilot technology for advisor productivity, AI implementation guidance through Elevate, and connection to partners with nonprofit AI expertise.

11.2 Salesforce Nonprofit Programs

Salesforce offers extensive nonprofit support through Salesforce.org and related initiatives:

Power of Us Program

- **10 Free Licenses:** Enterprise Edition Salesforce licenses at no cost for eligible nonprofits
- **80% Discount:** On additional licenses beyond the initial 10
- **Nonprofit Cloud:** Purpose-built CRM features for fundraising, program management, and volunteer coordination
- **Nonprofit Trailblazer Community:** 70+ global user groups, peer support, and shared best practices

Salesforce Accelerator – AI for Impact

Salesforce runs dedicated accelerator programs for nonprofits developing AI solutions. The most recent cohorts have received:

- **Grant Funding:** \$2 million distributed across selected nonprofits per cohort
- **Expert Coaching:** 6 months of intensive guidance from Salesforce experts and pro bono volunteers
- **Consulting Access:** 12 months of 1-on-1 consulting on generative AI, product design, and solution architecture
- **Donated Products:** 24-month contract for Salesforce products to support AI development
- **Total Investment:** \$9 million committed to accelerator programs since 2022

Relevance to AI Benefits Advisor:

Salesforce is the recommended CRM for case management and advisor workflows. The AI Benefits Advisor—with its focus on helping vulnerable populations access entitled benefits—aligns directly with Salesforce's social impact mission. Applying to the AI for Impact accelerator could provide: grant funding for development, expert guidance on AI implementation, pro bono consulting on product design, and extended access to Salesforce products.

11.3 Co-Creation Opportunity Assessment

Partner	Opportunity	Next Step
Microsoft	Azure AI hosting credits; Elevate program access; Copilot implementation support; nonprofit partner network	Register for Microsoft Nonprofit program; apply to Elevate initiative; engage with Tech for Social Impact team
Salesforce	AI for Impact accelerator application; Power of Us licenses; pro bono consulting; Agentforce for Nonprofits	Apply to next AI for Impact cohort (applications typically open annually); engage Salesforce.org UK team

Strategic Recommendation

The AI Benefits Advisor represents exactly the kind of high-impact, AI-powered social good project that both Microsoft and Salesforce actively seek to support. Independent Age should pursue both partnerships in parallel:

- 1. Immediate:** Register for Microsoft Nonprofit program and Salesforce Power of Us to secure baseline discounts
- 2. Near-term:** Engage with Microsoft Elevate and Salesforce.org UK teams to explore co-creation partnerships
- 3. Strategic:** Apply to Salesforce AI for Impact accelerator with the Benefits Advisor as flagship project

Potential benefits: £50,000-100,000+ in reduced technology costs; expert AI implementation guidance; credibility boost from major technology partner endorsement; ongoing support and community access.

12. Immediate Next Steps

1. Commission Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA)
2. Confirm professional indemnity insurance covers AI-assisted advice
3. Engage technology partners (Vapi, Azure, EntitledTo API)
4. Design shared intelligence core (modular architecture)
5. Build unified advisor dashboard (supervision + copilot)
6. Develop IVR integration (peak-hours opt-in)
7. Build knowledge base (RAG with DWP guidance)
8. Recruit pilot advisors (dashboard training)
9. Initiate CPAG licensing conversation (V2 knowledge expansion)

Appendix A: Sample Conversation Scenarios

The following scenarios illustrate the range of conversations the AI Benefits Advisor must handle. Each demonstrates specific challenges, appropriate AI responses, and escalation triggers.

A.1 The Reluctant First-Timer (Stigma Barrier)

Caller: Margaret, 78, widow, lives alone in Bradford. Struggles with mobility and dressing. Never applied for benefits.

Trigger phrase: "I don't want a handout. I've managed on my own all my life."

Margaret: "My neighbour said I should ring you. But I don't want charity. I've never asked for help."

AI Prompt to Advisor: [STIGMA BARRIER DETECTED] Suggest reframing. Source: Independent Age stigma guidance.

Advisor: "I completely understand, Margaret. Can I share something? These aren't handouts—they're entitlements you've already paid for through National Insurance your whole working life. It's like paying into an insurance policy and then not claiming when you're entitled. Would it be alright if I just asked a few questions to see what you might have paid in for?"

Margaret: "Well... I suppose if I've already paid for it..."

Advisor: "Exactly. Now, you mentioned your neighbour suggested calling. Can I ask—do you find some things around the house more difficult than they used to be?"

Margaret: "Getting dressed takes me ages now. And the bath—I haven't had a proper bath in months. I just can't get in and out safely."

AI Prompt to Advisor: [CARE NEEDS IDENTIFIED: dressing, bathing] Strong indicators for Attendance Allowance. AA is NOT means-tested—savings and income don't matter. Consider exploring day AND night needs for higher rate.

Key Learning:

The stigma barrier is real but surmountable. Reframing benefits as "entitlements already paid for" is more effective than emphasising need or deserving. The AI correctly identifies care needs language and prompts for Attendance Allowance exploration.

A.2 The Midnight Carer (Out-of-Hours, Time-Pressured)

Caller: Daniel, 54, full-time accountant, caring for mother (82) with dementia. Calling at 8pm after work.

Context: Time-pressured, efficient, wants clear answers. Mother unlikely to call herself due to cognitive decline.

Daniel: "Look, I've got about 20 minutes before I need to check on Mum. She's got dementia, she's 82, lives alone but I'm there every evening. She's on State Pension only—about £200 a week. What can she get?"

AI Prompt to Advisor: [TIME-PRESSURED CALLER] Prioritise efficiency. [THIRD-PARTY CALLER] Will need mother's consent for application. [DEMENTIA + LIVES ALONE + £200/wk] Strong indicators: Attendance Allowance (higher rate likely), Pension Credit (income below threshold), potential Severe Disability Addition.

Advisor: *"Thanks Daniel—let me be efficient with your time. Based on what you've said, your mum likely qualifies for three things: Attendance Allowance for her care needs—that's up to £108 a week and doesn't depend on savings. Pension Credit to top up her income. And if she gets both and lives alone, a Severe Disability Addition worth another £81 a week. We're potentially looking at £150-200 extra per week."*

Daniel: *"That much? Why has no one told us this before?"*

AI Prompt to Advisor: [BACKDATING OPPORTUNITY] AA can be backdated to date of claim. PC can be backdated 3 months. Highlight urgency of claiming soon.

Key Learning:

Adult children calling on behalf of parents are common. The AI adapts tone (efficient, direct) and identifies the cascade of benefits that interact. Note: formal application will require mother's involvement or appropriate authority.

A.3 The Code-Switcher (Multilingual, Bereaved)

Caller: Mrs. Khan, 76, primary language Urdu/Punjabi (Mirpuri dialect), husband deceased 18 months ago.

Context: Code-switches between Urdu and English. Worried about bills. May be eligible for bereavement-related benefits.

Mrs. Khan: *"Beta, I am worried. Mera gas bill bahut high hai. Mere husband—he passed away, you know. Ab main akeli hoon."* [Translation: My gas bill is very high. Now I am alone.]

AI Prompt to Advisor: [LANGUAGE: Urdu/English code-switching detected] [BEREAVEMENT: husband deceased] [FINANCIAL STRESS: energy bills] Explore: Pension Credit (widow's income change), Warm Home Discount (requires PC), Cold Weather Payments. Check if receiving full State Pension including any inherited amount.

Advisor: *"I'm so sorry about your husband, Mrs. Khan. Losing a partner is very hard—and worrying about bills on top of that must be stressful. Can I ask—since your husband passed, have you had anyone check what benefits you might be entitled to now that your circumstances have changed?"*

Mrs. Khan: *"Nahin, kisi ne nahin bataya. Mujhe kuch nahin pata."* [No, nobody told me. I don't know anything.]

AI Prompt to Advisor: [POTENTIAL UNDERCLAIM] Widows often miss: inherited State Pension rights, Bereavement Support Payment (if within 21 months), Pension Credit reassessment as single person. High priority for full benefit check.

Key Learning:

The AI handles code-switching naturally without asking caller to "speak English." Bereavement triggers specific benefit checks. Energy bill concerns are a gateway to discussing Pension Credit and passported benefits.

A.4 The Backdating Discovery ("I Should Have Applied Years Ago")

Caller: Arthur, 81, has had arthritis for 6 years but never claimed Attendance Allowance.

Emotional challenge: Realising years of entitled support were missed can cause distress and self-blame.

Arthur: "My daughter just told me about this Attendance Allowance. I've had this arthritis for six years—can barely do my buttons up. Are you telling me I could have been getting money all this time?"

AI Prompt to Advisor: [EMOTIONAL RESPONSE LIKELY] Caller discovering missed entitlement. Handle sensitively—avoid language that implies fault. [BACKDATING: AA cannot be backdated before claim date] Focus on future entitlement, not lost past.

Advisor: "I understand that's frustrating to hear, Arthur. You're certainly not alone—Attendance Allowance is one of the most under-claimed benefits, and lots of people don't hear about it until much later than they should. The good news is we can get your claim started today, and your payments will begin from when you apply. Let's focus on getting you what you're entitled to going forward."

Arthur: "But I've missed out on thousands of pounds!"

Advisor: "I know, and I wish the system did a better job of telling people. What I can tell you is that at £108 a week—which you may well qualify for—that's over £5,600 a year going forward. And if you're also eligible for Pension Credit, the Attendance Allowance can trigger an extra £81 a week on top. Shall we go through the questions together?"

Key Learning:

The AI prompts the advisor to handle the emotional impact of discovering missed entitlement. Focus shifts to future benefits rather than dwelling on losses. Specific pound amounts help reframe the conversation positively.

A.5 The Safeguarding Trigger (Financial Abuse Indicators)

SAFEGUARDING SCENARIO

Caller: Doris, 84, sounds hesitant. Adult son appears to be in the room.

Red flags: Third party controlling conversation, confusion about own finances, signs of coaching.

Doris: "My son said I should call about getting some extra money. He... he handles all my finances now."

AI Alert: [SAFEGUARDING FLAG: Third party financial control] [COACHING INDICATORS] Proceed with caution. Consider offering private callback.

Advisor: "Thank you for calling, Doris. Before we continue, I just want to check—are you comfortable talking freely right now, or would you prefer if I called you back at another time when you're on your own?"

[Background voice]: "Tell them you're fine, Mum."

Doris: "I'm... I'm fine."

AI Alert: [ESCALATE TO SUPERVISOR] Coaching confirmed. Flag case: SAFEGUARDING_REVIEW. Do not proceed with benefit application until private conversation possible. Offer to send written information to allow independent contact.

Key Learning:

The AI detects safeguarding indicators and immediately flags for supervisor review. The advisor offers a private callback opportunity without directly accusing anyone. The priority shifts from benefit application to ensuring the caller's safety and autonomy.

A.6 The Gateway Cascade (Pension Credit Unlocking Multiple Benefits)

Caller: Jean, 74, recently retired from part-time work, income dropped significantly.

Opportunity: Demonstrate how Pension Credit acts as a "gateway" to multiple other benefits.

Jean: "I stopped my little cleaning job last month—my knees just couldn't take it anymore. Now I'm only on my State Pension, about £180 a week. Things are getting tight."

AI Prompt to Advisor: [INCOME CHANGE TRIGGER] £180/wk below Pension Credit threshold (£218.15 single). [HEALTH ISSUE: knees] Potential AA eligibility. [GATEWAY BENEFITS] PC would unlock: Council Tax Reduction, Cold Weather Payments, Warm Home Discount, free NHS dental/prescriptions.

Advisor: "Jean, I'm glad you called. At £180 a week, you're likely eligible for Pension Credit, which would top your income up to at least £218. But here's what's really important—Pension Credit is what we call a 'gateway benefit.' Once you're receiving it, you automatically qualify for help with Council Tax, Cold Weather Payments when it's freezing, the Warm Home Discount on your electricity, and free NHS dental treatment and prescriptions."

Jean: "All of that from one benefit?"

Advisor: "Exactly. And you mentioned your knees—if you're finding everyday tasks difficult because of that, you might also qualify for Attendance Allowance, which is extra money on top and isn't affected by your other income. That could add another £72 or £108 a week. Shall we go through both?"

Key Learning:

The gateway benefit concept is powerful for demonstrating value. One Pension Credit application can unlock £3,000-5,000+ in annual benefits. The AI identifies the health mention and prompts exploration of Attendance Allowance as additional entitlement.

A.7 The Severe Disability Addition (Complex Interaction)

Caller: Harold, 79, already receiving Attendance Allowance (higher rate) and Pension Credit. Lives alone.

Complexity: Testing whether AI identifies the Severe Disability Addition—an extra £81.50/week many miss.

Harold: "I'm already getting the Attendance Allowance—the higher one, £108. And Pension Credit. I live on my own since my wife died. Is there anything else I might be missing?"

AI Prompt to Advisor: [CRITICAL CHECK: Severe Disability Addition] Harold meets ALL criteria: (1) Receiving AA/DLA/PIP middle or higher rate ✓ (2) Lives alone ✓ (3) No one receiving Carer's Allowance for him ✓. SDA is £81.50/week (£4,238/year). Verify this is included in his Pension Credit.

Advisor: "Good question, Harold. There's something called the Severe Disability Addition—it's an extra £81.50 a week added to your Pension Credit, and you qualify because you get the higher rate Attendance Allowance and live alone. Can I ask—have you got a recent Pension Credit letter that shows what's included?"

Harold: "I've got one here somewhere... It just says Guarantee Credit £218.15."

AI Alert: [UNDERPAYMENT DETECTED] Standard Guarantee Credit only. SDA appears missing. Harold should be receiving approximately £299.65/week (£218.15 + £81.50). Action: Request Pension Credit reassessment. Potential backdated payment.

Key Learning:

The Severe Disability Addition is frequently missed even by people already receiving Pension Credit. The AI must check for this whenever the criteria are met: receiving qualifying disability benefit + living alone + no one claiming Carer's Allowance for them.

— *End of Document* —

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